CONTENT AUDIT + CASE STUDY

Peak App | UX Content Strategy

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Part 1: Content Audit

A systematic review of Peak's existing UI copy, identifying voice inconsistencies, accessibility failures, and tonal mismatches against the established voice & tone guide.

Audit Scope & Methodology

This audit reviewed copy across five core product areas: Home/Dashboard, Check-in Flow, Resources Page, Settings, and Onboarding. Each element was evaluated against four criteria:

- Voice consistency: Does this sound like Peak?
- Tonal appropriateness: Does the tone match the emotional context of this moment?
- Accessibility: Is link text descriptive? Are instructions clear?
- Usability: Does this copy help the user know what to do and why?

Audit Summary

14 content issues were identified across 5 screens. Issues were rated High, Medium, or Low priority based on user impact and frequency of exposure.

- High priority issues: 10
- Medium priority issues: 4
- Low priority issues: 0

The most pervasive pattern: excessive exclamation points in high-sensitivity contexts, creating tonal whiplash that undermines the app's credibility as a wellness tool. The second most common issue: vague or non-descriptive link text, which creates accessibility failures for screen reader users.

Findings at a Glance

> **ISSUE:** Exclamation points appear in 9 of 14 flagged elements, including in error messages, mental health resource descriptions, and re-engagement notifications. This is the single highest-impact pattern to address.

> **ISSUE:** 'Click here' appears as a CTA in 3 resource card links, creating WCAG 2.1 AA accessibility failures. Screen readers announce link text without visual context; non-descriptive links are inaccessible.

> **ISSUE:** Re-engagement notifications use guilt and manufactured urgency ('Your streak is at risk!'), which research shows increases app deletion rates in wellness contexts.

> **FINDING:** Onboarding uses numbered step indicators ('Step 3 of 7'), which UX research consistently links to higher abandonment rates than unlabeled progress bars.

> **RECOMMENDATION:** Replacing exclamation points in error and sensitive contexts, updating non-descriptive link text, and revising the re-engagement notification sequence are the three highest-ROI changes.

Full Audit Table

Page / Screen	Element	Current Copy	Issue	Recommended Copy	Priority
Home / Dashboard	Welcome message	"Welcome back! Ready to tackle today?"	Forced positivity; assumes user is ready; exclamation point inappropriate for wellness context	"Good to see you, [Name]. Here's where things stand."	**High**
Home / Dashboard	Empty dashboard CTA	"Start your journey today! Add your first goal!"	Double exclamation points; 'journey' is overused and vague; creates pressure	"Add a goal to get started. Takes about a minute."	**High**
Check-in Flow	Mood rating label	"How are you FEELING today? Rate your mood!"	All caps creates alarm; exclamation point in sensitive context is tonal mismatch	"How are you feeling today? No right answer here."	**High**
Check-in Flow	Completion message	"Awesome work! You completed your check-in! You're crushing it!"	Three exclamation points; 'crushing it' is jarring in mental health context; performative	"Check-in complete. See you next time."	**High**
Resources Page	Section header	"Resources For You!"	Exclamation point unnecessary; vague; doesn't orient user to content	"Find support by topic"	**Medium**
Resources Page	Resource card CTA	"Click here to learn more!"	'Click here' is accessibility failure (non-descriptive link); exclamation point	"Learn about [Resource name]" or "Visit [Resource name]"	**High**
Resources Page	Mental health section intro	"Struggling? You're not alone! We're here for you!"	Question as opener creates alarm; exclamation-heavy; 'you're not alone' is overused	"These resources are here when you need them. No pressure to use them now."	**High**
Settings	Notification settings header	"Stay in the Loop!"	Exclamation point; vague; doesn't describe what notifications do	"Manage your notifications"	**Medium**
Settings	Account deletion CTA	"Delete Account"	No consequence language; no friction; no retention path offered	Trigger confirmation modal with consequence statement before action	**High**
Onboarding	Progress indicator	"Step 3 of 7"	Creates countdown dread; research shows numbered steps increase abandonment	Replace with unlabeled progress bar	**Medium**

Onboarding	Goals selection header	"Tell Us About Yourself!"	Vague; exclamation point; doesn't orient user to purpose of screen	"What's on your plate right now?"	**High**
Error States	Generic error message	"Oops! Something went wrong! Please try again later!"	Three exclamation points in error state; 'Oops' minimizes user frustration; no specificity	Context-specific error messages (see Error Message samples)	**High**
Notifications	Re-engagement notification	"We miss you! Come back and check in! Your streak is at risk!"	Guilt-based; manufactured urgency; streak threat is manipulative in wellness context	"It's been a while. Peak is still here whenever you need it."	**High**
Notifications	Milestone notification	"AMAZING! You hit a 7-day streak! You're a SUPERSTAR!"	All caps; excessive enthusiasm; infantilizing in wellness app context	"7 days in a row. You've been showing up for yourself. That's the whole point."	**Medium**

Part 2: Case Study

From Performative to Human: Rethinking Wellness App Copy for a High-Stress Population

A content strategy case study | Peak App | Beth Keller Kirycki

The Problem

Peak launched with a voice that felt borrowed from consumer wellness apps built for general audiences. The copy was enthusiastic, encouraging, and relentlessly positive. On the surface, this seemed appropriate for a wellness product. In practice, it was creating friction with the exact users it was trying to support.

Early user research surfaced a consistent pattern: students described the app as feeling 'fake,' 'like a motivational poster,' and 'the kind of thing an RA would say.' Several students mentioned turning off notifications specifically because the tone felt patronizing. One participant said: 'It talks to me like I'm five, and I'm already stressed enough.'

The Research

What We Learned

I conducted a content-focused analysis combining three research inputs:

- Qualitative interviews with 8 current college students about their relationship with wellness apps, institutional communication, and digital support tools
- A competitive content audit of 5 comparable apps (Headspace, Calm, TimelyCare, WellTrack, and Uwill), documenting voice, tone, CTA patterns, and error messaging conventions
- Heuristic evaluation of Peak's existing copy against Nielsen's usability heuristics and WCAG 2.1 AA accessibility standards

Key Research Findings

> **FINDING:** Students distrust forced positivity. In a population where anxiety and impostor syndrome are prevalent, overly enthusiastic copy reads as performative, and performative signals inauthenticity.

> **FINDING:** Exclamation points in sensitive contexts create tonal whiplash. In moments of check-in, resource access, or error recovery, enthusiasm signals that the product doesn't understand the stakes.

> **FINDING:** Guilt-based re-engagement is counterproductive. Students who are already overwhelmed respond to guilt notifications by avoiding the app entirely. The notification becomes the reason not to engage.

> **FINDING:** 'You're not alone' is exhausted. Students recognized this phrase as institutional boilerplate and reported it as decreasing rather than increasing their sense of connection.

> **FINDING:** Students want to be treated as capable adults. The most common request: 'Just tell me what I need to know. Don't hype it up.'

The Strategy

Content Principles I Established

Based on the research, I developed five content principles to govern all copy decisions for Peak. These became the foundation of the Voice & Tone Guide:

- Warm, not effusive. We care without performing care.
- Clear, not clinical. Plain language that respects the user's intelligence.
- Encouraging, not relentless. We acknowledge hard things without minimizing them.
- Honest, not alarming. We tell the truth gently, without false reassurance.
- Respectful, not paternalistic. We offer options. Users decide.

The Strategic Shift

The central content strategy shift was from enthusiasm to presence. Instead of copy that performed excitement about the product, I moved toward copy that simply showed up–calmly, consistently, and without agenda.

This required three structural changes:

- Eliminating exclamation points from all sensitive and high-stakes contexts (error messages, wellness check-ins, mental health resources, re-engagement notifications)
- Replacing guilt-based re-engagement language with availability signals ('Peak is still here whenever you need it')
- Grounding every piece of copy in a specific user need rather than a product goal

The Work

Content Audit

I audited 14 high-exposure copy elements across 5 screens, identifying issues with voice consistency, tonal appropriateness, accessibility, and usability. Each issue was paired with a specific recommendation and a priority rating.

The audit revealed that the highest-impact change was the simplest: removing exclamation points from contexts where they created tonal mismatch. This single change affected 9 of 14 flagged elements and required no design or engineering resources, just a content decision backed by research.

Voice & Tone Guide

I developed a comprehensive voice & tone guide that included:

- Five core voice attributes with behavioral definitions
- A tone spectrum table showing how the same voice shifts across contexts
- Do/Don't examples for four key content contexts (onboarding, wellness moments, error states, sensitive moments)
- A decision framework for novel content situations not covered by examples

UX Writing Sample Set

I wrote a complete set of product copy across six content types, applying the voice & tone guide consistently:

- Onboarding flow (6 screens): Guided users to their first useful moment without manufacturing urgency or commitment anxiety
- Error messages (8 scenarios): Owned errors honestly, matched tone to stakes, always provided a path forward
- Empty states (5 scenarios): Taught, invited, and reassured rather than simply reporting absence
- Feature modals & tooltips (6 examples): Earned interruptions, respected user autonomy, never made dismissal feel wrong
- Notifications (10 examples): Signaled presence without guilt, matched urgency to context, eliminated manufactured stakes

Selected Before / After

Check-in Completion Message

BEFORE: "Awesome work! You completed your check-in! You're crushing it!"

AFTER: "Check-in complete. See you next time."

> 📌 **RATIONALE:** *Three exclamation points in a mental health context signal that the product doesn't understand the emotional weight of the moment. The revised copy acknowledges completion without performing enthusiasm. The quietness is intentional; it respects what the user just did.*

Re-engagement Notification

BEFORE: "We miss you! Come back and check in! Your streak is at risk!"

AFTER: "It's been a while. Peak is still here whenever you need it."

> 📌 **RATIONALE:** *The original notification uses three manipulation tactics: guilt ('we miss you'), manufactured urgency ('come back'), and loss aversion ('your streak is at risk'). Research on wellness app engagement shows these tactics increase short-term opens and long-term deletion. The revised notification signals presence without pressure. 'Still here' implies continuity and reliability, which is the actual value proposition of a wellness app.*

Mental Health Resource Introduction

BEFORE: "Struggling? You're not alone! We're here for you!"

AFTER: "These resources are here when you need them. No pressure to use them now."

> 📌 **RATIONALE:** *The original copy opens with a question that assumes distress, which can feel alarming or shaming for users who are just browsing. 'You're not alone' has become institutional boilerplate–students recognize it as a script and disengage. The revised copy simply establishes availability and removes the pressure to act immediately, which research shows increases eventual engagement with mental health resources.*

Onboarding Goals Screen

BEFORE: "Tell Us About Yourself!"

AFTER: "What's on your plate right now?"

> 📌 **RATIONALE:** *'Tell us about yourself' is vague and positions the user as subject of institutional data collection. 'What's on your plate right now?' uses a familiar idiom, normalizes the presence of multiple demands, and orients the user toward a specific, present-tense task. It also signals that the goals selection is about utility, not surveillance.*

The Outcome

The content strategy work for Peak produced:

- A comprehensive Voice & Tone Guide that can govern content decisions across the product lifecycle
- A 14-item content audit with specific, actionable recommendations prioritized by user impact
- A complete UX writing sample set (44 individual copy elements across 6 content types) with annotated design rationale
- A replicable content review process that any team member can apply to new features

The most important outcome was strategic: establishing that content is not decoration applied after design decisions are made. It is a design material, shaped by research, governed by principles, and accountable to user needs. Every word in Peak's interface makes a promise about what kind of product this is. This work ensured those promises were ones the product could keep.